

Ashes on your mobile

Zapak, Jump Games and Codemasters have collaborated to release Ashes, a cricket game for mobile users

14 million

Analysts pegged the sales of SuperSpeed USB 3.0 devices to 14 million by 2010 and predict a further 12x jump by 2014

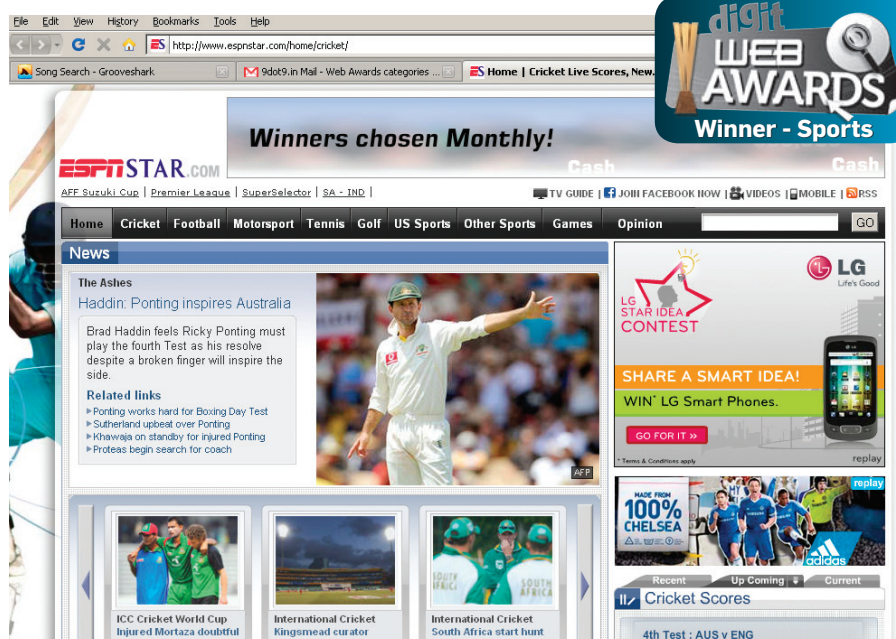
SPORTS

Sports following in India is about as divided as the Soviet Union – one huge section and many little pockets of “others”. We’re obsessed with cricket as a country, but there are still those who follow other sports. As expected, we couldn’t really find any popular web site that was dedicated to a sport other than cricket. In fact, Espnstar.com was the only web site that’s popular in India to carry news of other sports as well – and traffic stats show that this is probably the reason why non-cricket junkies flock here.

We shortlisted five sites for the showdown: Espnstar.com, Cricinfo, Cricbuzz.com, Cricket365.com and Cricketworld.com.

The load times for almost all these sites were respectable, with Cricbuzz clocking the lowest time. As far as the first look of the site goes, we loved Cricketworld.com for its neatly separated columns and a striking background (‘Ashes’ at the time of testing). Also important is the number of news articles the site can provide on a single page in a neat layout. Cricketworld was tops with a well populated and neat homepage.

As far as the content of these sites goes, they are all at par, as far as news articles are concerned. However, the thing that sets a sports site apart is the quality of opinion articles and blogs. Cricinfo and EspnStar take the lead here. Cricinfo has more than a dozen



blogs, comprising writers from around the world. From Andy Zaltman’s pain-inducingly-funny *The Confectionery Stall* to Samir Chopra’s thoughtful *Different Strokes*, Cricinfo blogs make good reading for anyone with the slightest interest in cricket. Espnstar, however, maintains a catalog of blogs and opinion articles over a wide array of sports. They are usually updated once a week, as compared to almost three new blog entries on Cricinfo everyday.

However, keeping the user hooked to a sports site is a different art altogether – provide more news and articles, closely related in topic and chronology to the current article. Cricbuzz provides the maximum avenues from a single article with visible boxes for both related news and latest news. Espnstar provides related stories that can keep you hooked. All sites except Cricbuzz provide a readily accessible search-box, but Cricinfo really pulls away from the competition here. It provides a comprehensive search, providing separate search results for stories, video/audio, blogs, photos and player bios. It even provides ‘Quotes’ matching the search query, along with interesting articles from the Wisden Almanack. When we searched for “Sachin”, it kept us hooked for a good part of our office hours. The other sites have decent engines, but they search only for news.

Sports enthusiasts thrive on discussions and dissection of matches. Cricketworld and Cricket365 provide not-so-active forums, while Espnstar and Cricinfo have Facebook communities with 92,248 and 286,140 likes, respectively, at the time of writing. Espnstar and Cricinfo really use the power of their Facebook communities by implementing F-Connect and Disqus commenting systems that aggregate comments from Facebook and the web site. Trust us, 92 thousand people can start some really interesting conversations.

Live-scores are a must for all of us these days, and none of the sites miss out on this popular feature. Mobile portals are another must according to us, and Cricinfo has by-far the best mobile portal. Cricbuzz has a similar mobile portal while Espnstar has a wap-style, operator-tied mobile portal that provides wallpapers, videos etc. for paid download.

After having a good look at the what these sites provide, the scores brought Espnstar and Cricinfo neck-and-neck. Espnstar, however, just edged ahead because of its wider coverage of different sports. The most popular sports site in India, Cricinfo is a close second. The site is impressive and addictive, and is playing its part in keeping India hooked to its favourite sport. **d**

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